

Constantine

Constantine I the Great (272–337 CE) was the last pagan and first Christian emperor of Rome, initiating his empire's conversion to Christianity and the development of Byzantine culture. Early architectural commissions, such as the Baths of Constantine in Rome, reflect the pagan past, but others, such as the Aula Palatina at Trier in Germany, are Christian. As well as the great church of St Peter, his achievements include the completion of the huge Basilica Nova, modelled on the frigidaria (cold rooms) of bath complexes, and the Arch of Constantine (opposite), commemorating victory over his rival Maxentius. Built of marble blocks and brickwork riveted with marble, the arch is 21 metres (69 ft) high, 26 metres (85 ft) wide and 7.4 metres (24 ft) deep. Each façade features four Corinthian columns of yellow Numidean marble, as well as decorations salvaged from as far back as the Emperor Trajan (98–117 CE). In 324, Constantine founded Constantinople as the 'new Rome', and his interest in building found expression there in the churches of the Holy Wisdom ([see here](#)) and of the Apostles.

